Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 3.6 Guided Notes: Social-Emotional Development Across the Lifespan

Unit 3: Development and Learning | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic3.6

Word Bank

Attachment Styles	*Insecure Attachment*	*Ecological Systems Theory*
Mesosystem	*Anxious Attachment*	*Contact Comfort*
Temperament	*Chronosystem*	*Exosystem*
Macrosystem	*Separation Anxiety*	*Avoidant Attachment*
Disorganized Attachment	*Secure Attachment*	*Microsystem*

1. Bronfenbrenner's Environmental Layers

To understand human development, we cannot look at an individual in a vacuum. The _____ asserts that human development is profoundly shaped by multiple nested, interacting environmental systems ranging from immediate personal connections to broad cultural contexts. These environmental layers are divided into five distinct systems:

- _____: The immediate, face-to-face environment an individual directly interacts with on a daily basis, such as family members, classmates, neighborhood peers, and school teachers.
- _____: The structural interactions and relationships that occur between different components of a person's microsystem, such as a parent meeting with a schoolteacher or the connection between a child's home life and peer group.
- _____: External environmental settings or institutions that indirectly affect a person's development, even though the individual is not directly involved in them, such as a parent's workplace policies or community healthcare services.
- _____: The overarching cultural context encompassing the shared values, societal laws, political ideologies, and economic customs that indirectly mold development across a community.
- _____: The temporal dimension of time, including major life transitions, historical shifts, and changes in socio-historical circumstances that influence an individual's developmental path over their life course.

Apply It: Which Environmental Layer?

Using the word bank above, identify which layer best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Layer
1	A teenager's daily interactions with her parents, best friend, and math teacher directly shape her mood and behavior every single day.	
2	A school counselor specifically reaches out to a student's parents after noticing the student struggling, creating a direct link between the student's home life and school life.	
3	A country's cultural belief that hard work and individual achievement are highly valued shapes how children are raised, even though no child ever directly interacts with “the culture” itself.	
4	A woman who grew up during a major economic recession approaches saving money completely differently than someone who grew up during a period of prosperity, showing how the historical era someone lives through shapes their outlook.	

2. Infancy, Temperament, and Attachment

An infant's social journey begins with their biological _____—an individual's inborn, genetically driven pattern of emotional reactivity and behavioral self-regulation that manifests early in life. This foundational biological trait directly influences how children form _____, which are the characteristic patterns of emotional bonding and relationship behavior that develop from early interactions with primary caregivers.

Historical studies with infant monkeys demonstrated the profound importance of _____ over biological nourishment in attachment. When frightened, the monkeys systematically sought refuge with a soft cloth surrogate mother rather than a wire surrogate mother that provided food, proving that this tactile comfort is vital for emotional security.

Ainsworth's Attachment Classifications

When attachment figures leave, healthy infants often display _____—heightened emotional distress, fear, or crying triggered by being separated from a primary caregiver or encountering a stranger. To study these reactions systematically, Mary Ainsworth developed the “Strange Situation” laboratory paradigm. In this procedure, an infant is observed playing in a room while their caregiver and a stranger take turns entering and leaving. By watching how the child reacts to the stress of these separations and the subsequent reunions, researchers identified distinct styles of bonding that vary dynamically across cultural environments:

- _____: A healthy pattern where children feel completely safe and supported by their caregiver, using them as a secure base to explore new spaces, expressing distress when they leave, and being easily comforted upon their return.
- _____: A broader pattern where a child does not feel consistently safe, valued, or supported by a caregiver, giving rise to anxious, avoidant, or unpredictable behavioral dynamics in close relationships.
- _____: A specific insecure style characterized by conspicuous emotional distance, extreme discomfort with intimacy, and a coping tendency to rely entirely on oneself rather than seeking support from caregivers or peers.

- _____: An insecure pattern marked by a strong, needy desire for extreme closeness mixed with an intense, pervasive fear of rejection or abandonment, resulting in constant worry and relational instability.
- _____: An insecure style lacking any coherent behavioral strategy, where children show confused, dazed, or contradictory responses toward caregivers, typically stemming from fear, abusive trauma, or severely erratic caregiving.

These early childhood bonds heavily predict how adults form romantic and familial connections later in life.

Apply It: Which Attachment Style?

Using the word bank above, identify which style best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Style
1	A toddler happily explores a new playroom, occasionally glancing back to check that her mother is still nearby, gets upset when her mother steps out, but calms down quickly and returns to playing once her mother comes back.	
2	A young boy shows almost no reaction when his caregiver leaves the room and barely acknowledges her when she returns, seeming to prefer playing with toys alone rather than seeking any comfort from her at all.	
3	A toddler freezes in place with a blank, confused expression when her caregiver re-enters the room, sometimes approaching her and then suddenly backing away, showing no consistent pattern of behavior at all.	

Word Bank

Identity Achievement	*Parallel Play*	*Authoritative Parenting*
Personal Fable	*Permissive Parenting*	*Identity Moratorium*
Adolescent Egocentrism	*Identity Foreclosure*	*Pretend Play*
Imaginary Audience	*Identity Diffusion*	*Authoritarian Parenting*

3. Caregiving Frameworks: Parenting Styles

The stylistic demands and responsiveness of caregivers play a massive role in child outcomes, though cultural differences heavily modulate these effects. Caregivers generally fall into one of three primary categories:

- _____: A highly successful style characterized by high expectations combined with warmth, emotional support, and open, democratic communication. This approach encourages children to cultivate personal responsibility and healthy independence.
- _____: A restrictive style characterized by high demands and rigid rules coupled with incredibly low emotional responsiveness. It demands absolute obedience and strict discipline over mutual warmth or constructive discussion.
- _____: A lax style characterized by high warmth and emotional responsiveness but incredibly low behavioral demands or household rules. This approach grants children immense freedom with little structural discipline, boundaries, or expectations.

📺 *Video Notes: "Review Video: Adolescence"*

Watch the video above, then answer each question below in your own words.

1. In Harlow's monkey experiment, what were the two artificial mothers, which did the baby monkeys prefer, and what does the video say about the ethics of the study?

2. How did Ainsworth's Strange Situation work, and how does the video describe the three attachment styles?

3. According to the video, what shapes whether a child becomes securely or insecurely attached, and why does attachment matter for later life? Include the Romanian orphanage example.

4. How does the video describe the three parenting styles, and which approach does the research favor?

Apply It: Which Parenting Style?

Using the word bank above, identify which style best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Style
1	A father lets his teenage son skip curfew, stay up as late as he wants on school nights, and never enforces any household chores or rules, prioritizing his son's happiness above any structure.	
2	A mother demands that her children finish every bite of dinner and go to bed at exactly 8:00 PM without question, refusing to explain her reasoning and punishing any pushback immediately.	

4. Peer Dynamics and Play Milestones

As children mature, their social spheres widen beyond the family circle. In early childhood, peer interaction primarily manifests through distinct developmental stages of play:

- _____: A stage where young children play adjacent to one another in the same space, utilizing similar toys, but do not directly interact or coordinate their play activities.
- _____: An advanced play milestone where children use active imaginations to project roles, enact complex scenarios, and utilize objects symbolically to represent entirely different things.

As individuals transition into adolescence, they gradually rely far more on peer relationships for validation and support than on their parents.

Apply It: Parallel or Pretend Play?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Two toddlers sit right next to each other at a sandbox, each building their own separate sandcastle, completely absorbed in their own project without speaking to or looking at one another.	
2	A group of children takes turns "cooking" imaginary meals in a play kitchen, assigning each other roles like chef and customer, fully acting out an elaborate restaurant scenario.	

5. Adolescence, Cognition, and Identity

During the teenage years, cognitive development prompts a unique flare-up of _____—a heightened self-focus where individuals struggle to separate their personal concerns from the thoughts of those around them. This egocentrism breeds two distinctive cognitive distortions:

- _____: The strong bias that others are constantly observing, monitoring, and judging one's appearance, actions, and minor blunders far more than they actually are.
- _____: The deep belief that one's internal thoughts, feelings, and life experiences are completely unique, special, and invulnerable, leading to the idea that others cannot truly understand them.

Marcia's Identity Statuses

Building on the adolescent quest for a stable sense of self, teenagers are classified into four distinct identity statuses based on whether they have gone through an exploration crisis and made a firm life commitment:

- _____: The status where an individual has thoroughly explored various options and successfully made a committed choice regarding their values, career goals, and core beliefs.
- _____: The status where an individual is currently in the midst of an active crisis, exploring options and alternative paths, but has not yet settled on a definitive commitment.
- _____: The status where an individual blindly commits to specific values, goals, or lifestyle expectations handed down by parents or authority figures without ever independently exploring alternative choices.
- _____: The status where an individual has neither explored identity options nor made any meaningful commitment to specific values, directions, or life beliefs. This identity search also shapes familial, occupational, and racial/ethnic identities.

Apply It: Which Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A teenage boy is convinced that every single person in the cafeteria noticed and is silently judging the small stain on his shirt, even though almost nobody actually looked at him.	
2	After trying out several different clubs, majors, and even a few different friend groups, a college senior has finally settled confidently on a career path and a clear set of personal values she feels genuinely reflect who she is.	
3	A college freshman has no idea what he wants to study, hasn't seriously thought about his future career, and doesn't feel particularly invested in exploring any specific path yet.	
4	A young man planned to become a doctor for as long as he can remember simply because both of his parents are doctors, and he has never seriously questioned or explored any other possible career path.	

Word Bank

Emerging Adulthood	*Social Clock*
Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACEs)	*Initiative vs. Guilt*
Intimacy vs. Isolation	*Autonomy vs. Shame and Doubt*
Identity vs. Role Confusion	*Industry vs. Inferiority*
Generativity vs. Stagnation	*Integrity vs. Despair*
Trust vs. Mistrust	

6. Psychosocial Stages Across the Lifespan

Developed by Erik Erikson, the stage theory of psychosocial development argues that individuals must successfully confront and resolve a specific psychosocial conflict at eight different stages across the lifespan to develop adaptively. Using the word bank above, fill in the name of each stage:

#	Life Stage & Conflict	Stage Name
1	(Infancy) Babies learn to view the world as a safe, predictable, and reliable place if their caregivers provide consistent, responsive care; irregular or cold care leads to pervasive insecurity.	
2	(Toddlerhood) Children strive to develop physical independence and self-control over basic tasks. Success breeds autonomy, while harsh criticism or overprotection can result in deep self-doubt.	
3	(Early Childhood) Children begin to assert power, plan tasks, and take charge through play. Encouragement creates leadership confidence, whereas heavy restrictions foster a sense of inadequacy.	
4	(Middle Childhood) School-aged children strive to master formal academic and social skills. Success produces competence, while repeated failure or teacher criticism can leave them feeling inferior.	

#	Life Stage & Conflict	Stage Name
5	(Adolescence) Teenagers explore different social roles, values, and career goals to construct a cohesive sense of self. Failing to navigate this stage results in a fragmented sense of direction.	
6	(Early Adulthood) Young adults focus on forming deeply close, mutually vulnerable romantic and platonic relationships. Success brings love and connection, while failure results in loneliness.	
7	(Middle Adulthood) Middle-aged adults focus on contributing to society, working productively, and guiding the next generation. Failure to find a meaningful contribution results in a feeling of unproductiveness.	
8	(Late Adulthood) Older adults look back and reflect on their life choices. A sense of fulfillment brings wisdom and ego integrity, while focusing on missed opportunities yields bitter regret.	

📋 *AP Core Exclusion: Sigmund Freud's controversial psychosexual stage theory of development is explicitly outside the scope of the AP Psychology Exam. Focus your study time entirely on Erikson's psychosocial stages!*

7. Adulthood Transitions and Trauma

Social development continues into adulthood as individuals navigate cultural guidelines. Many societies follow a _____—a culturally shared expectation or prescriptive "timetable" for when major milestones (such as finishing school, marrying, or retiring) are supposed to happen, influencing whether individuals judge themselves to be "on time". Many modern cultures now recognize a transitional phase known as _____ (roughly ages 18–25), a bridge between adolescence and full adulthood marked by intense exploration of identity and career paths.

Finally, social development can be heavily disrupted by _____ (ACEs)—potentially traumatic events like abuse, neglect, or severe household dysfunction occurring early in life. Experiencing ACEs can have profound, long-lasting impacts on physical health, mental health, and relationship patterns across the lifespan, though significant sociocultural differences exist regarding how these traumas affect outcomes.

📺 *Video Notes: "Review Video: Adolescence and Adulthood"*

Watch the video above, then answer each question below in your own words.

1. How does the video use The Breakfast Club to illustrate Erikson's identity vs. role confusion stage, and what does it say teens are doing during it?

2. How does the video describe Erikson's overall model, and what issue does it name for young, middle, and late adulthood (with approximate ages)?

3. What is emerging adulthood, according to the video, and what evidence does it give for it?

4. What physical changes does the video describe in adulthood, and how do fluid and crystallized intelligence change with age?

5. What is dementia, according to the video, how does it relate to Alzheimer's disease, and is it part of normal aging?

Apply It: Which Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A 24-year-old still living with roommates, switching jobs frequently, and figuring out both his career and his identity says he doesn't feel like a "real adult" yet but isn't a teenager either.	
2	A man feels embarrassed and privately anxious at family gatherings because, unlike his siblings, he hasn't yet bought a house by the age his culture generally expects.	
3	A therapist explains that a client's difficulty trusting others and chronic health issues as an adult can often be traced back to a turbulent, neglectful childhood home environment involving ongoing family instability.	

8. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Authoritative vs. Authoritarian: This is one of the most common traps on the AP Psychology Exam! To protect your score, remember that the AuthoriTATive parent is "Totally Awesome" because they listen, explain rules, and show high warmth. The AuthoriTARian parent is like a dictatorial "Totalitarian" ruler who expects blind obedience without discussion.

9. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. A child's father experiences a stressful, demanding schedule after his company implements a strict new overtime policy, and this added stress indirectly makes him more irritable and less patient with his son at home, even though the son has never even visited his father's workplace. This indirect environmental influence is called the:

- **A.** Macrosystem
- **B.** Microsystem
- **C.** Mesosystem
- **D.** Exosystem

2. During the Strange Situation procedure, a toddler clings desperately to her mother, becomes intensely distressed when separated, but then pushes her mother away angrily upon reunion while still clearly desperate for closeness, showing an unpredictable mix of neediness and resistance. This specific insecure attachment style is called:

- **A.** Disorganized Attachment
- **B.** Avoidant Attachment
- **C.** Secure Attachment
- **D.** Anxious Attachment

3. A set of parents maintains high expectations for their children's behavior and achievement, but they also explain their reasoning behind household rules, listen to their children's opinions, and offer plenty of warmth and emotional support. This parenting style, which encourages independence and personal responsibility, is called:

- **A.** Authoritarian Parenting
- **B.** Insecure Parenting
- **C.** Permissive Parenting
- **D.** Authoritative Parenting

4. A 16-year-old girl believes that no one, not even her own parents, could possibly understand the intensity and uniqueness of her personal heartbreak after a breakup, convinced that her emotional experience is entirely unlike anything anyone else has ever felt. This cognitive distortion, common during adolescence, is called the:

- **A.** Imaginary Audience
- **B.** Identity Moratorium
- **C.** Adverse Childhood Experience
- **D.** Personal Fable

5. According to Erikson, a young child who is encouraged to plan and lead her own games during playtime develops confidence and leadership skills, while a child who is heavily restricted from taking any charge may develop a sense of inadequacy. This stage is called:

- **A.** Initiative vs. Guilt
- **B.** Autonomy vs. Shame and Doubt
- **C.** Industry vs. Inferiority
- **D.** Generativity vs. Stagnation

6. A 30-year-old woman feels significant social pressure and personal anxiety because she has not yet gotten married or had children, since her culture holds a shared, unspoken expectation that these milestones should typically happen by a certain age. This culturally shared timetable for major life milestones is called the:

- **A.** Personal Fable
- **B.** Emerging Adulthood
- **C.** Social Clock
- **D.** Chronosystem

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz